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Ereshkigal (deity)

Ereshkigal is an ancient goddess from Mesopotamian mythology, revered as the ruler of the underworld, known as Irkalla. She is unique in her ability to maintain order in her realm and is the sole judge of the dead. Ereshkigal is often depicted as fierce, embodying themes of judgment, death, and transformation, and is sometimes associated with aspects of birth and the afterlife. She is notably the sister of Inanna (or Ishtar), with whom she shares a tumultuous relationship characterized by jealousy and rivalry, culminating in Inanna's temporary demise in the underworld. Ereshkigal is also connected to Nergal, the god of war and plague, who becomes her husband after a series of myths detail their dramatic encounters, including themes of love, power, and conflict.

Her lineage traces back to Anu, the father of the sky, and her depiction in art, such as the Burney Relief, illustrates her striking features and regal stance. Ereshkigal's influence extends beyond Mesopotamian culture, as her narrative has parallels in Greek and Hebrew mythology, highlighting the universal themes of the afterlife. The hymns and poems associated with her, particularly the "Descent of Inanna," reflect significant cultural and spiritual practices related to life, death, and the natural world. Overall, Ereshkigal represents the complexity of existence, encapsulating the cycles of life and the inevitability of death, serving as a powerful figure in ancient mythological traditions.

Published in: 2022

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Ereshkigal (deity)

Symbols: Rod; owls; lions; wings

Culture: Mesopotamian

Wife of: Nergal and Gugalanna

Father: Anu or Skygod

Siblings: Inanna or Ishtar

Children: Ninazu; Nungal; Namtar

One of the oldest goddesses in Mesopotamian culture, Ereshkigal is the goddess of the underworld or land of the dead. She is the only one who had the power to maintain lawfulness in her kingdom. Known to be fierce, she was also the only one who could pass judgement on the dead. In some texts, she has also been associated with birth or afterlife. According to Babylonian culture, she was the sister of [Inanna](#), or [Ishtar](#), and also her arch enemy. Her relationship with Ishtar was one of hatred and jealousy, which led to Ishtar being banished from her kingdom. Ereshkigal was the wife of Nergal, the god of war and plague and there are several mythical versions of how they met and how Ereshkigal relinquished her powers to Nergal. She is also believed to have had another mortal husband, Gugalanna, with whom she had a son, Ninazu. Ereshkigal was the daughter of one of the chief gods, Anu, or father of the sky. On the Burney Relief, a terra cotta plaque on display at British Museum, she is depicted as naked, with wings, standing on the back of two lions with two owls on her side. The relief is said to be the closest iconographic depiction of the goddess to her textual description. She has also been depicted as having dark thick hair and sleeping on a gemstone called lapis lazuli. The most important temple dedicated to her by the Mesopotamians has been found in Cuthah, in modern day Iraq. She was revered in cultures spread over Turkey, Egypt, and Saudi Arabia.

In Mythology

There are two prevalent myths about the two important people in Ereshkigal's life story—her husband Nergal and her sister Inanna. One of the most prominent mentions about Ereshkigal is in the Sumerian (related to Southern Mesopotamian culture) poem titled "Descent of Inanna," from around 1900–1600 BCE, in which

on being asked at the door of entrance of the underworld, why Inanna wished to enter the land of the dead, she answered, "Because of my older sister, Ereshkigal. Her husband, Gugalanna, the Bull of Heaven, has died. I have come to witness the funeral rites." But Ereshkigal did not take this gesture from her sister too well and asked her gatekeeper Neti to bolt all the seven entrances to the palace but one. At each entrance Inanna was required to remove her ornaments, clothes, scepter, gold ring, and all her possessions. Finally, as she neared the throne of Ereshkigal, Ereshkigal put Inanna to death following a judgement passed against Inanna by the judges of Ereshkigal's kingdom. But Inanna was brought back to life by her father-god, Enki. Inanna and Ereshkigal also represent change of seasons with Inanna representing seasons of life and Ereshkigal a symbol of death and decay or transformation in the nature.

Another interesting aspect of her life is how she fell in love with Nergal, the god of war. According to one myth, Ereshkigal belonged to the family of the sky gods but was kidnapped and sent to the underworld and made queen of the underworld. During her reign, Nergal came to the underworld and forced her to marry him. He threatened to destroy her kingdom if she refused.

According to another account, Ereshkigal wanted to be in the company of gods of the heavens, Anu (also her father), Enlil, and Ea. But because of her inability to go back to the heavens, the gods asked her to send her servant to take back her share of gifts from the heavens. She sent her son and servant Namtar. Namtar was received with great respect in the heavens except by Nergal, the god of war and diseases. Nergal was sent to the underworld as a punishment for his bad behavior. He was also advised to not have any kind of physical intimacy with Ereshkigal. But when he caught a glimpse of her taking a bath, he failed to resist his temptation and gave in to his desires. Nergal left her after six days to go back to the heavens. On learning of Nergal's departure, Ereshkigal was hurt, angry, and she longed to be with Nergal. After pleading to the gods of heaven to send Nergal back, she threatened them that if he was not asked to return to the underworld, she would bring the dead back to life in large numbers. Nergal relented and returned to his love. On his return, he became the king of the underworld and ruled the kingdom along with Ereshkigal.

Origins and Cults

The myth of Ereshkigal and the concept of the underworld or a world for the dead influenced other cultures, such as the Greeks and Hebrews. The Mesopotamian belief in Irkalla or the underworld is similar to the Greek idea of [Hades](#), which is also the place for departed souls. The concept of the underworld also bears close resemblance with Sheol, a Hebrew concept, though it does not allow for the

existence of goddess like Ereshkigal. The Sumerian poem, "Descent of Inanna," is also symbolic of changes in nature. It also describes rituals and traditions to be followed with respect to life and death as taught in the temples of those days. As the religion evolved, so did the mythological narrative. Many believe that the story of Nergal ruling as the king of the underworld is a much later addition explained by the later dominance of male characters in **Mesopotamian civilization**. Going by a more spiritual interpretation, the descent of Inanna into the underworld symbolized a woman's spiritual journey crossing layers of one's outer existence as the end neared.

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